the overall superiority of the Chinese both in numbers and weaponry; the shortages faced by the Indian troops on all fronts, ranging from clothing to rations to ammunition; the abysmal rate of retrieval of air supplies; and the difficulties posed by the terrain and the cold. He stated in unambiguous terms that it was nearly impossible for the Indian troops to expel the Chinese and advised an immediate withdrawal from Nam Ka Chu to a sounder position that was logistically and tactically defensible.

When Kaul finished speaking, he expected the matter to be settled then and there. As the group digested Kaul's 'new' understanding of the situation, a pensive Nehru said he did not want a situation where Indian troops would be committing suicide. He then asked for suggestions as to what needed to be done in the circumstances.

As we have seen, Bogey Sen, despite commanding the Eastern Army, had never been to Nam Ka Chu. Nor had the COAS, Pran Thapar. Both these officers had in fact been sidelined in what until now was the 'General Kaul Show'. Perhaps in a bid to reassert their own positions, both Sen and Thapar now argued against Kaul—Sen saying that regardless of the conditions, a full brigade should be able to hold a defensive line even against superior forces. Kaul's earlier bluster now made it impossible for him to speak up against the army commander and the chief, who clearly outranked him in the chain of command.

Nehru and Menon, perhaps loath to invite the criticism that would have followed a pullout from the Nam Ka Chu, for once decided to go against the advice of Kaul and backed Sen and Thapar. Unable to convince the COAS and the government, Kaul returned to Tezpur. The next day Nehru left for Colombo and during a stopover at Madras, made grand statements about 'throwing out the Chinese from our territory'. Both the Indian and the international press, which hailed it as a declaration of war on China, seized upon these remarks. To make matters worse, on 17 October, Menon, Thapar and Sen converged on Tezpur where Kaul now continued to argue for a strategic withdrawal from Tsangle and Bridge 5. After the events of 10 October, the Chinese had nullified the strategic importance of this location. Again Thapar and Sen hardened their stand, and ordered the corps commander to move 1/9 GR to Tsangle as reinforcements. These decisions (11 and 17 October) were not communicated to either 7 Brigade or 4 Division.